



US President Jimmy Carter (center) looks on as President Anwar Sadat of Egypt shakes hands with Menachem Begin, Israel's premier, after signing a peace treaty at the White House in 1979.

from Jordan, meaning Israel was now an occupier. In the 1970s and '80s, the Arab–Israeli conflict largely moved in the direction of peace: in 1979 the Israeli–Egypt peace deal ended 30 years of war. The rise of the Palestine Liberation Army (PLO) and of other Palestinian groups attacking Israel, however, as well as Israel's invasion of Lebanon in 1982, where many of the PLO were grouped, destabilized the fragile peace continuously.

The Iran–Iraq War

Like many countries in the Middle East, modern Iraq was carved out of the ruins of the Ottoman Empire in the aftermath of World War I. Iraq was a land divided along ethnic lines between Arabs and Kurds, as well as sectarian lines between Sunni and Shia Muslims, the latter being the majority group. Saddam Hussein, a Sunni, became leader in 1979, and suppressed ethnic Kurds and Shias alike using immense brutality. He, like Nasser in Egypt, espoused Arab nationalism and ruled Iraq as a secular state.

In 1979, events in Iran inspired Islamists throughout the Middle East. The secular, Western way of life was swept away in an

Islamic revolution in which the US-backed Shah was ousted. The new regime, under Ayatollah Khomeini, a Shia Muslim, based its laws and ideology on the strict teachings of the Quran. Saddam felt threatened by the Islamic revolution and a possible Shia uprising in his own country, so he invaded Iran on September 22, 1980, under the pretext of a territorial dispute over the Shatt al-Arab, a waterway that lies between the two countries.

The invasion triggered a bruising eight-year war that devastated both countries and increased tensions in the Middle East. Iran's principal ally was Syria, but Libya, China, and North Korea all also sent it weapons. Iraq's support came mostly from the Arab Gulf states, which viewed Iran as the greater danger to their security; Saudi Arabia and Kuwait provided billions of dollars in loans. Ultimately, there were no victors; and Iraq, now awash with armaments supplied by several Western nations, including Britain, France, and the United States, invaded the oil-rich state of Kuwait in 1990. The UN demanded their withdrawal, but Saddam announced that Kuwait had been annexed by Iraq. The United States, with support from coalition forces, sent in troops during the First Gulf War (1990–1991) and freed Kuwait.

The 9/11 attacks

The continued US support of Israel led to profound grievances among Islamists. To them, the capitalist, secular US, with its greed for oil, symbolized all that was wrong with the West, and terrorist strikes on US targets grew. Al-Qaeda carried out the most shocking on September 11, 2001, against four targets in the United States, including the World Trade Center in New York City.

In response to the 9/11 attacks, a successful US-led international intervention brought down the Taliban regime in Afghanistan, which the US believed had given sanctuary to Osama bin Laden and al-Qaeda. After September 11, President Bush declared a “War on Terror” and, in 2002, with help from the British government, attacked Iraq on the premise of destroying “weapons of mass destruction” (WMDs) deemed a threat to national security.



During the First Gulf War, Iraqi forces set fire to more than 600 Kuwaiti oil wells. Saddam Hussein's desire to control Kuwaiti oilfields had initially led to Iraq invading Kuwait in 1990.